WAHKIAKUM COMMON GROUND

Watershed Restoration and Salmon Recovery Progress

Wahkiakum County depends on a **healthy salmon fishery** for commercial, tribal, and recreational purposes, but salmon populations are currently at risk. Watershed restoration projects can improve habitat for fish while also benefitting the resilience of the community.

Photo: Chinook Salmon, Roger Tabor/USFWS

SALMON IN WAHKIAKUM COUNTY

Historically, tens of millions of salmon returned to the Columbia River each year. Now, only about two million do, and two-thirds of these fish are hatchery-raised. The decline in salmon populations is due to multiple factors including habitat loss, overharvesting, hatchery practices, and predation. Columbia River and Puget Sound salmon and steelhead are listed under the Endangered Species Act.

WATERSHED RESTORATION

Watershed restoration consists of strategic efforts to improve or revive watershed ecosystem health and functionality. This can involve many different approaches, such as bank stabilization, removal of fish barriers such as undersized culverts, adding in-stream woody structures, reconnecting floodplains, and planting native trees and shrubs. Recovering fish populations by connecting local projects with resources is the goal of regional recovery organizations coordinated by the Governor's Salmon Recovery Office. For example, in Wahkiakum County, the Lower Columbia Fish Recovery Board (LCFRB) seeks to recover salmon and steelhead to healthy, harvestable levels.

Want to know more? Visit https://beav.es/WCG

Wahkiakum County MRC

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SALMON RECOVERY PROGRESS

Good news! Overall, long-term declines in salmon and steelhead populations have been halted. In 2024, LCFRB (lcfrb.org) reported that since Endangered Species Act listing in 1999, more than a third of 72 regional fish populations have improved viability. Restoring fish habitat has played an important role in that upswing. The long history of neglect and recovery takes time. However, scientists are optimistic about the early trends showing increasing viability of these culturally and economically important fish.

MULTI-BENEFIT WATERSHED RESTORATION

Watershed restoration efforts have improved habitat for fish and wildlife while reducing loss or flooding and erosion of private and public infrastructure and contributing to the economic vitality of Wahkiakum County. Collaboration between county, regional, special district, state, tribal, nonprofit, and community leaders is key to the success of these efforts.

Photo: Nelson Creek Restoration

***Wahkiakum County** relies on a healthy salmon fishery for commercial, tribal, and recreational purposes, yet salmon populations are threatened. Efforts to support sustainable fisheries by restoring watersheds also have benefits for the community: reducing risk from coastal hazards, boosting economic vitality, and improving emergency preparedness.*

To learn about multi-benefit watershed restoration **SUCCESS STORIES** in Wahkiakum County or to **get involved** visit:

https://beav.es/WCG